A TUG OF WAR

The factors favouring theatre commands for the Indian military, and ones that go against it

PLUSES

- **One war, one commander—ensures all three services fight as one**
- **Better use of assets, as scarce fighter jets, ships, drones come under unified command, not service silos**
- **Faster response—shortens decision chain in crises like a China–Pakistan two-front war**
- **The best way to fight future wars across land, air, sea, cyber and space domains**

MINUSES

- **No clarity on command and control systems**
- **With an inadequate number of squadrons, the IAF fears loss of flexibility due to division of assets**
- **Inadequate integration of communication networks, still-maturing defence industry bode ill for theatrisation**
- **Risk of reduced utilisation—integration could dilute current branch-specific expertise**

EARLY STEPS TOWARDS JOINTNESS HAVE STARTED, LIKE CROSS-POSTING JUNIOR OFFICERS AND SETTING UP A JOINT DIVISION AT THE DEFENCE SERVICES STAFF COLLEGE

plans, ironing out disagreements. If we still can't act, when shall we?" asks a senior defence official. With threats from China and Pakistan intensifying, he believes the consequences of inaction could be dire.

GOALS AND SHORTCOMINGS

Officials at the CDS office believe that theatre commands would prepare the Indian military for future wars, where synergy and joint operations across land, sea, air, cyber, and space domains will determine results. Without this shift, they say, India's war-fighting ability risks remaining fragmented and outdated.

In June 2025, CDS Gen. Chauhan, in the preface to his newly released book *Ready, Relevant and Resurgent: A Blueprint for the Transformation of India's Military*, stated that theatrisation would seek to create two parallel and complementary streams: one for 'force application' and another for 'force generation'. Force application, or military operations, will be managed by theatre commanders reporting to the CDS, while the service chiefs will focus on preparing, training and maintaining the forces. However, some experts say this command and control model, with reduced operational roles for the chiefs, would foster confusion and a command vacuum.

Most military planners say that the proposed theatre command model draws from US and Chinese doctrines. But India, they point out, faces a different reality, with unique threat perceptions. With equipment shortages, an ageing air fleet, inadequate inter-service integration of communication networks, non-availability of commanders and staff trained in joint services environments and a still-maturing defence industry, full-scale theatrisation could strain an already stretched force.

WAY FORWARD

Military experts emphasise that there must be focus on establishing the organisational structure, including clearly defined headquarters, command hierarchies and control mechanisms. Without such structural clarity, integration could result in inefficiency during crises. Training officers in jointness is a priority. As one defence official asks, "How can an army officer, trained in ground warfare, be expected to direct complex air operations with the same competence?"

Though they performed admirably together during Op. Sindoor, further integration of army and IAF air defence assets is another priority. "The current siloed structure not only leads to duplication but also limits operational effectiveness, especially in fast-moving, high-threat air environments," says Lt Gen. Anil Ahuja (retd), former deputy chief, Integrated Defence Staff. He adds there is a strong case for the rationalisation of helicopters and medium-lift air assets between the two, as joint ownership or centralised coordination would enhance flexibility, responsiveness and asset utilisation.

The Indian military has already taken some initial steps towards tri-services integration. The CDS has identified several tasks to enhance jointness across the services and those focusing on improving operational efficiency and administrative effectiveness, like cross-posting of junior officers and appointing aide-de-camps (ADCs) from sister services. A joint division at the Defence Services Staff College in Wellington to foster inter-services understanding and cooperation has been set up.

Experts say that before a full-scale rollout of ICTs, the revised organisational structures should undergo rigorous wargaming at top war colleges, followed by field testing in a selected theatre or command. This approach would provide insights and ensure refinements. Only then can the Indian armed forces be fighting ready for a nationwide adoption of theatre commands. ■